Leave Policy

This document sets out the leave rules for all permanent employees of Meridian Traders. It applies to every office and to every field representative, whether they report to the West, South, North or East team. The rules below replace the earlier handbook chapter on time off.

The leave year runs from 1 January to 31 December. Balances are tracked in whole and half days. Managers approve leave in the HR portal; email approval is accepted only when the portal is unavailable, and the record must be entered within two working days.

Questions about this document go to the HR helpdesk. The HR head owns the text and reviews it every year in December. Changes take effect on the date printed on the cover page and are announced on the notice board and by email.

Paid leave for new employees

A new joiner is entitled to 18 days of paid leave in the first year, accrued monthly. The entitlement is credited at one and a half days on the first working day of each month, starting with the month of joining. A new joiner may take accrued leave after the probation review, which happens at the end of the third month.

From the second year onward the entitlement rises to 21 days of paid leave, credited in the same monthly manner. Unused paid leave of up to 10 days carries over into the next year; anything above that lapses on 31 December.

Paid leave covers vacations, family events and personal errands. It is separate from sick leave, casual leave and maternity or paternity leave, which are described on the following pages. Half-day paid leave is allowed, and a half day counts as 0.5 against the balance.

Sick leave and casual leave

Every employee receives 12 days of sick leave each year, credited in full on 1 January or on the date of joining for a mid-year start. Sick leave of more than two consecutive days needs a medical certificate submitted within three working days of returning to work.

Casual leave is 6 days per year for short, unplanned absences. Casual leave cannot be combined with paid leave in a single request and cannot be carried into the next year.

Sick leave and casual leave balances are not paid out on exit. Paid leave balance is settled in the final payroll at the basic salary rate.

Maternity, paternity and special leave

Maternity leave is 26 weeks of fully paid leave, available from up to 8 weeks before the expected date. Paternity leave is 10 working days, to be used within three months of the birth. Adoption leave follows the same durations.

Bereavement leave of 5 days is granted on the loss of an immediate family member. Marriage leave of 3 days is granted once. Both are in addition to the paid leave balance.

Study leave for an approved certification can be taken for up to 10 days per year, unpaid, subject to the manager confirming that the course relates to the role.

Public holidays and office closures

The company observes 10 public holidays per year. The list for the coming year is published every November and differs by office to reflect local festivals. Field representatives follow the list of the office they report to.

If an employee is asked to work on a public holiday, a compensatory day off is credited and must be used within 60 days. Compensatory days are tracked separately from paid leave.

The office closes between 25 December and 1 January. Those days are not deducted from any balance. Staff on critical support rosters receive compensatory days for the closure period.

Applying for leave and record keeping

Requests for paid leave of up to 3 days should reach the manager at least one week ahead. Requests for longer absences need two weeks of notice. Sick leave is reported on the day by phone or message and entered in the portal when the employee returns.

Unapproved absence of three consecutive days is treated as leave without pay and is reported to HR. Repeated unapproved absence may lead to disciplinary action.

HR publishes each employee's balance in the payslip every month. Disputes about a balance must be raised within 30 days of the payslip date. The HR helpdesk answers within five working days.